

Does a Secular Course in Religious Studies Reduce Religiosity? A Proposed Randomised Experiment

Essay for the course "Introduction to Causality" Nikita Obraztsov, European University at St. Petersburg, 2025

Introduction

For this assignment I chose to design a study connected to my main research interest: religious deconversion. In contemporary sociology of religion, understanding the preconditions of deconversion is an active area of inquiry. Education is considered one such precondition, and an empirical association between education and deconversion has been documented in a number of countries, including the United States. Whether this pattern is universal remains contested: some cross-cultural studies have failed to replicate it.

That said, the correlation appears in the majority of existing studies of religiosity. Identifying the actual causal mechanism behind this pattern, however, is a separate and still unresolved research problem.

This is precisely why causal analysis is necessary. Statements like "higher education is a predictor of religious deconversion" sound scientific, but without a clear understanding of the underlying mechanism they are disconnected from reality. Treating "education as such" as a cause is also questionable: education correlates with an enormous number of other variables, social environment, financial situation, urban residence, and multicollinearity is practically unavoidable. For this reason, the study proposed here tests not the effect of education in general, but the effect of completing a specific course.

The research question is: does taking a secular course in the history of religions affect religiosity?

The hypothesis is that acquiring this kind of general knowledge may, on average, produce a decrease in religiosity among students who receive the treatment. Given what we know about religion and religiosity in the contemporary world, education is closely linked to both individual beliefs and social practices. The hypothesis therefore has concrete empirical and theoretical grounding and calls for experimental testing.

The main methodological challenge is the difficulty of isolating the effect of education — or even of a particular course. Higher education is typically obtained while living in a large city or on a campus, which may itself affect deconversion. Education, in other words, is an extremely diffuse concept that is hard to work with in causal analysis. A researcher can at best describe and document a tendency, but cannot claim to have identified full causality.

The proposed solution is to use randomisation to isolate one specific factor associated with education and measure its effect on religious deconversion. That factor is completing a course in the history of religion and secular ethics, taught from a secular perspective.

Research Design

The experiment divides students into two groups at random. An experimental group takes a course in the history of religions with an emphasis on cognitive biases and comparative analysis of religious traditions. Before the course begins, both groups complete a survey measuring religiosity and cognitive dogmatism. After the course ends, the survey is administered again, making it possible to observe any changes and estimate the causal effect.

The control group takes a worldview-neutral course, for instance, academic writing. The experimental group takes a purpose-built history of religion course that covers the origins and development of religion and the most common cognitive biases and errors, in a neutral and non-confessional manner. The course involves in-person seminars (two academic hours per week) and written assignments — essays or text-based work. The curriculum is developed by secular religious studies specialists.

Independent variable: the secular religious studies course itself. According to the hypothesis, completing it should statistically significantly increase the probability of a decrease in religiosity and of deconversion.

Dependent variable: change in religiosity. The measurement challenges are discussed below.

Mediating variable: change in participants' cognitive dispositions. The hypothesis holds that cognitive dispositions should change in a way and to a degree that produces a statistically significant decrease in religiosity in the experimental group. Cognitive restructuring can thus be understood as the general downstream effect of the treatment.

Randomisation allows us to approximate, as closely as possible, the ideal scenario in which we compare the same individuals across two worlds, one in which they received the treatment and one in which they did not. This is the counterfactual principle. It is the mechanism through which causality can be modelled in this setting.

Limitations and How to Address Them

This study comes with a considerable number of methodological limitations.

Defining and measuring religiosity. The sociology of religion has yet to resolve the question of how to define religion and religiosity. For the purposes of this study, I apply the five-dimensional model developed by Rodney Stark and Charles Glock, which includes religious belief, religious practice, religious experience, religious knowledge, and the influence of religion on everyday life. This framework has a substantial track record in describing and

measuring religiosity at both the individual and community level. For the present study, the key indicator is the importance of religion in the individual's life: the question used by organisations such as the Pew Research Center and Gallup. However, a person's position on this question may not change quickly, so additional indicators will be needed to capture shifts in religiosity.

Cross-contamination. Students may discuss their courses with each other, which could affect results. It is very difficult to prevent such discussions, or to estimate the social contagion effect separately.

Selection bias. To avoid distortions in the assignment of participants to experimental and control groups, the following approach is used: a pool of participants is formed, then clustered by gender, age, field of study, and religiosity, and only then divided into two roughly equal groups using a randomiser, so that the representative structure is preserved.

Social desirability bias. Respondents may artificially inflate or deflate their reported religiosity based on their perception of social norms and expected behaviour. To address this, the survey should include a large number of questions, with those directly related to religion comprising no more than five to ten percent of items. The study should be blind, participants should not know that their religiosity is the object of interest.

Ethical concern. Is the goal of the experiment to change religious preferences — effectively, anti-religious propaganda? It is important to be clear that the aim is to study the dynamics of religious preferences, not to change any individual's position. Finding no change in religiosity after the course would also be a meaningful scientific result.

Conclusion

The proposed study of the causal relationship between education and religious deconversion is built around isolating the effect of completing a specific educational programme. Multicollinearity is addressed through randomisation and the construction of representative experimental and control groups, one of which receives the treatment and one of which does not.

The significant methodological constraints involved in studying religion and religiosity as such deserve emphasis. Developing and testing a model of this kind could make a substantial contribution to the sociology of religion. The study could later be extended: we might separately estimate effects on individual-level and group-level religiosity, and apply the experimental design to different social groups.

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